

The Great British Bake Off

By the Numbers

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Introduction

In this statistical report, we will analyze a dataset from The Great British Bake Off (GBBO). In addition to providing an overview of the observations and variables, it will highlight the winners, the content's age, gender, and race, as well as any missing data. The central questions explored in this report concern who competes and who wins, particularly with respect to age, gender expression, and apparent race. By examining distributions and frequencies across these variables, this report aims to illuminate patterns that may reflect broader social dynamics within the show. The dataset includes 192 contestants across 16 series, with variables ranging from demographic information to competition performance.

The Data Set

As stated in the introduction, this data set is derived from the GBBO, but let's dive deeper into the variable types and what we can glean from them. The nominal variables in the data are Gender Expression, Apparent Race, Occupation, Hometown, Series, and Publisher. There are only a handful of interval and ratio variables: Age, Number of Star Bakers, and Ranking. Lastly, we have only one ordinal variable in the data set: Placement. With that in mind, the following charts and visuals will show when different statistical measures are appropriate, how to read distributions for both numerical and categorical data, and why it is important to let the data guide our analysis rather than relying on assumptions.

Who Are Our Winners

Let's see the winners of each series, their gender expression, age, occupation, and the number of times they won Star Baker (Table 1). Breaking it down: out of all the bakers, nine out of 16 are women, meaning seven out of 16 are men, or 56.25% & 43.75%, respectively. As for the winners' ages, we have a minimum of 20, a mean of 32.50, a median of 31, a mode of 30, and a maximum of 60 (an age range of 40). Moving on to Star Baker, we have a minimum of 0, a mean of 1.88, a median of 2, a mode of 2, and a maximum of 5. ß

Winners Infomation

Series	Baker	Gender Expression	Age	Occupation	Star Baker
1	Edward "Edd" Kimber	Male	24	Debt collector for Yorkshire Bank	0
2	Joanne "Jo" Wheatley	Female	41	Housewife	1
3	John Whaite	Male	22	Law student	1
4	Frances Quinn	Female	31	Children's Clothes Designer	1
5	Nancy Birtwhistle	Female	60	Retired Practice Manager	1
6	Nadiya Hussain	Female	30	Full-time mother	3
7	Candice Brown	Female	31	PE teacher	3
8	Sophie Faldo	Female	33	Former army officer and trainee stuntwoman	2
9	Rahul Mandal	Male	30	Research scientist	2
10	David Atherton	Male	36	International health adviser	0
11	Peter Sawkins	Male	20	Accounting & finance student	2
12	Giuseppe Dell'Anno	Male	45	Chief engineer	2
13	Syabira Yusoff	Female	32	Cardiovascular research associate	3
14	Matty Edgell	Male	28	Teacher	2
15	Georgie Grasso	Female	34	Paediatric nurse	2
16	Jasmine Mitchell	Female	23	Medical student	5

Table 1 - Winners of The Great British Bake Off, Series 1-16: a breakdown of each winner's name, gender expression, age at time of winning, occupation, and number of Star Baker titles earned during their series.

David Atherton of Series ten won with zero Star Bakers, the only contestant to do so, discounting Edd from Series one, who is marked as having won zero Star Baker because the title was not given out during that series (Figure 1).

Total Star Baker Awards by Series Winner

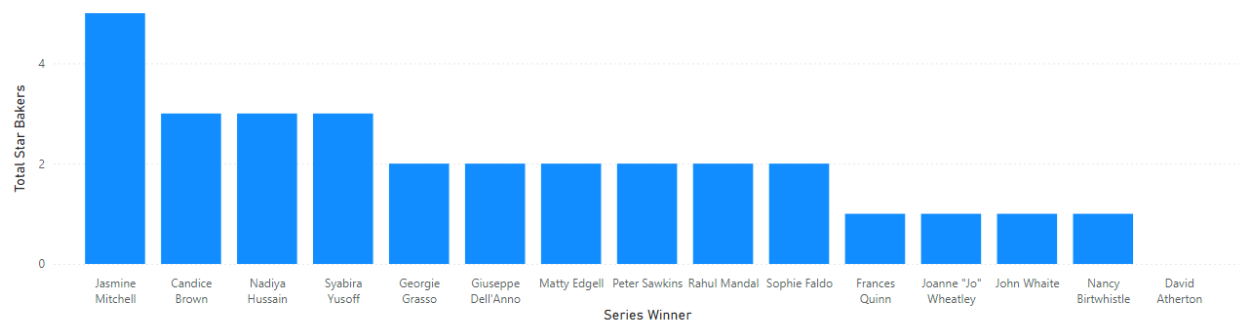


Figure 1 - Total Star Baker awards earned by each series winner of The Great British Bake Off, ranked in descending order. Edward "Edd" Kimber (Series 1 winner) is excluded, as the Star Baker award did not exist during the first series. Jasmine Mitchell leads with 5 awards, while David Atherton is the only remaining winner to have earned none.

Gender & Race

Breaking down the contestants and winners, we can see that 9 winners were presented as women, and 97 contestants were presented as women; 13 winners were presented as white, whereas 140 contestants were presented as white (Figure 2). Drilling down into this, we can see that seven of the 16 winners are white women, and 68 of the contestants are white women (Figure 3). This yields 43.75% and 35.42%, respectively, an 8.33-percentage-point gap, indicating that white women win the show at a higher-than-expected rate. It's worth noting that the number of white contestants is declining slightly in later series.

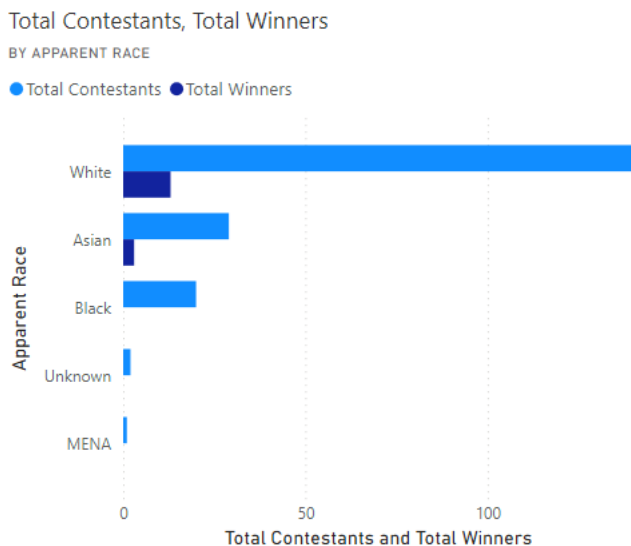


Figure 3 - Total contestants versus total winners on The Great British Bake Off, broken down by apparent race. White contestants make up the large majority of both the overall contestant pool and series winners, while Asian and Black contestants appear at notably lower rates, and MENA & Unknown categories have had no series winners to date.

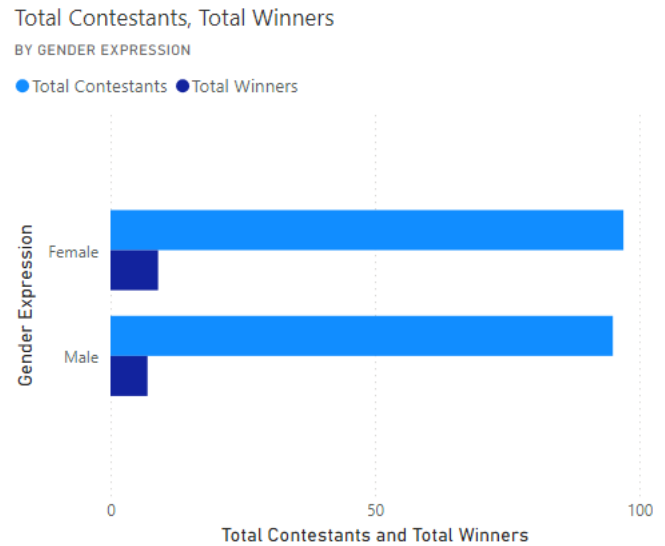


Figure 2 - Total contestants versus total winners on The Great British Bake Off, broken down by gender expression. The contestant pool is nearly equal between female and male participants, and the winner split is similarly close, with female winners holding a slight edge.

There are several better ways to account for racial identities assigned to a single race. First, and the best in this case, is to add *Multiracial* or *Mixed* categories, since this data is based on observed rather than reported data. Adding one of these categories allows for the acceptance of multiracial identities without assigning them to the contestant. Beyond adding the *Multiracial* or *Mixed* categories, the data set could allow multiple racial identities for each contestant. The best option would be to use self-identification, but because not all contestants do, this is not possible with this data.

How Old?

Age Distribution of GBBO Contestants

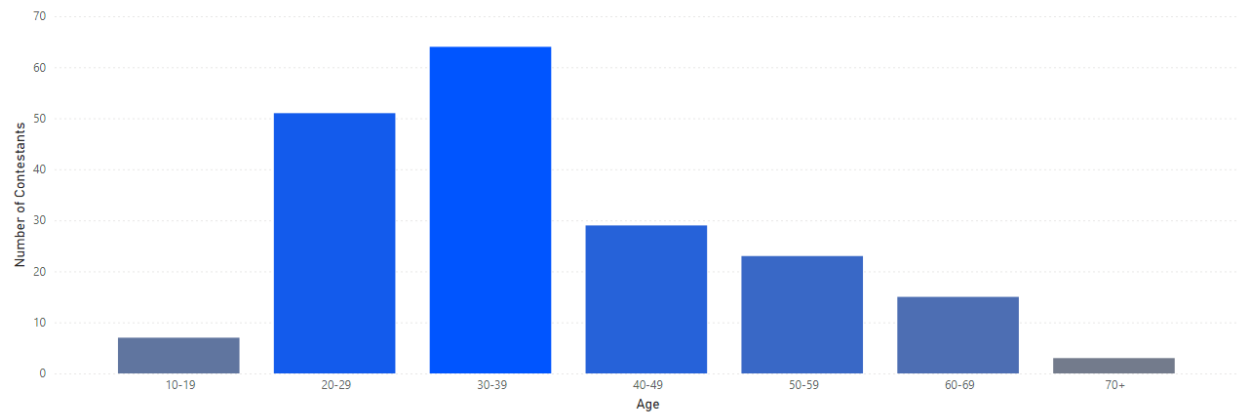


Figure 4 - Age distribution of The Great British Bake-Off contestants across all series. The 30–39 age group is the most represented, followed closely by those in their 20s, with participation dropping off steadily among older age groups and remaining minimal at the extremes.

Contestant Ages Distribution	
Age Group	Count of Baker
10-19	7
20-29	51
30-39	64
40-49	29
50-59	23
60-69	15
70+	3
Total	192

Table 2 - Contestant age distribution across all series of The Great British Bake Off, grouped into seven age brackets. Of 192 total contestants, the majority fall between 20 and 39 years old, with the 30–39 group being the largest.

The age range of the contestants is 17–71 (54 years); we have a mean of 37.57, a median of 33, and a mode of 31. We have a right-skewed distribution, with most contestants between 30 and 39 years of age, followed by those between 20 and 29 (Figure 4 & Table 2).

What's Missing?

The main variables missing from this dataset are as follows: whether the contestants had any formal culinary training or were entirely self-taught, detailed scoring information, and the contestants' education level, which would help round out the dataset. In addition to expanding this data, a complementary dataset on the judges could help identify any bias they may have.

Conclusion

This descriptive analysis of The Great British Bake Off identifies several notable patterns. Winners are generally younger than the overall contestant pool, with a mean winning age of 32.50 compared to 37.57 for all contestants. White women are overrepresented among winners relative to their proportion in the contestant pool, winning at a rate 8.33 percentage points higher than expected. The age distribution of contestants is right-skewed, with a peak in the 30–39 range. These findings prompt further inquiry into which forms of culinary creativity are recognized and rewarded. The primary limitations of this dataset include reliance on observer-assigned race and gender, absence of culinary training and education data, and lack of detailed episode-level scoring.

Work Cited

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